GEMS OF INDIA

SEVEN SISTERS DEVELOPMENT ASSISTANCE (SeSTA), *Guwahati*

Key people: **Varsha Mehta,** Chairperson; **Pradyut Bhattacharjee,** Executive Director

Year of inception: **2011**



WOMAN POWER TO THE FORE

As SeSTA spurs development in the Northeast, it draws ever closer to its goals: eliminating poverty, empowering women, and ensuring good health and climate change resilient villages

By **ATIQUL HABIB**

Development, covering the entirety of citizens' economic lives, is an inalienable right. Thus, it all began with a question: why is Northeast India, despite its dense networks of community action, deprived of development institutions that stayed long enough to understand local realities? Founded on the principle of *nirman*—constructive development—Seven Sisters Development Assistance (SeSTA) grew out of the belief that lasting change would come not from short-term projects, but from building livelihoods, institutions and confidence from the ground up.

SeSTA's development works show up in quiet ways—women learning to negotiate market prices, households opening their first bank accounts, fallow land returning to use. The organisation sees itself as a catalyst enabling rural communities, especially women and marginalised groups, to move beyond cycles of poverty while holding on to cultural roots. SeSTA's work weaves together economic activity and social inclusion. Poultry and pig farms, handlooms and agriculture are paired with training, access to welfare schemes, financial/ digital literacy and climate-resilient practices.

Nirali Rabha runs a pig farm, initially funded by SeSTA, since 2021.

EXPERTSPEAK

"SeSTA knows that rural livelihoods are a way of life. This grounding gives it an edge: early investments in locally suited pilots to groom persons who combine skill with commitment to rural development"

DHRUBA JYOTI GOGOI
State Project Manager, Assam State Rural Livelihoods Mission